PHYSIOS: A Standalone Operating Environment for Imitation-Learning Workflows on Low-Cost Robot Arms

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***Abstract*—Learning manipulation skills from human demonstrations has become practical on inexpensive hardware, but the surrounding workflow—planning demonstrations, recording them, curating the data, training and diagnosing a policy, and running it on the robot under supervision—is usually spread across scripts, notebooks and loosely coupled web tools. This paper describes PHYSIOS, an independent application that unifies this workflow for the SO-101 arm on top of the ROBOTIS Physical AI Tools stack, ROS 2 and LeRobot. PHYSIOS adds a standard-library gateway that fronts the existing robot-side node, a host training service and camera server through one versioned API and one origin, and serves the operators' existing web interface, organised as a numbered workflow. Design goals were independence from the earlier user interface, unchanged robot-side code, explicit operator initiation for every motion, and honest reporting of unavailable services. We describe the architecture, the safety model (typed confirmations, server-enforced motion gating, a joint envelope derived from the demonstrations, heartbeat-based holding, and a staged readiness process for custom robots), the training-optimisation loop based on controlled trials from a pre-problem checkpoint, and a compact interface design. Validation so far uses real back-end code with simulated robot and trainer stand-ins: 22 gateway tests, 91 training-service tests, 45 planning tests, a 26-step browser walk-through of the whole workflow, an optimisation-view check, sign-in walk-throughs and a containerised deployment. Verification on the physical robot and with GPU training is outstanding and is listed explicitly.**

***Index Terms*—imitation learning, robot learning infrastructure, vision-language-action models, ROS 2, LeRobot, human–robot interaction, safety, web-based robot interfaces**

I. Introduction

Vision-language-action (VLA) models such as RT-2 [1], OpenVLA [2], π_0 [3] and the compact SmolVLA [4], together with action-chunking and diffusion policies [5], [6], have made it realistic to teach a low-cost arm a task from a few dozen teleoperated demonstrations. Open libraries such as LeRobot [7] provide data formats, training scripts and policies; ROS 2 [8] provides the robot middleware.

What remains difficult for a small lab is the *workflow*. In the project that motivated this work, an operator recorded 39 leader–follower demonstrations of a cube pick-and-place task with two cameras and fine-tuned SmolVLA on them. Offline, the policy reproduced the demonstrations closely and on the robot it reached the cube; a reliable grasp required better matched camera conditions and more data. Each of these steps lived in a different tool: a ROS-based recording interface, command-line training, ad hoc evaluation and separate rollout scripts. Decisions such as *which* demonstrations to collect next or *whether* a training run diverged were made by inspecting logs by hand.

PHYSIOS ("The Operating System for Physical Intelligence") addresses this by providing one independent application for the complete loop: plan → record → curate → train and optimise → evaluate → run under supervision. Its contributions are:

- an architecture that adds an application layer *without modifying* the robot-side node, so an existing SO-101 setup keeps working unchanged (Section IV);
- a safety model in which every motion requires explicit operator initiation and is gated by the server, not only by the user interface (Section VI);
- a training-optimisation procedure based on controlled trials from the last healthy checkpoint (Section V);
- an interface design that favours density and status visibility for operators (Section VII); and
- a transparent validation report that separates simulated from physical evidence (Section VIII).

II. Background

ROBOTIS Physical AI Tools [9] combine LeRobot with a ROS 2 node (`physical_ai_server`) that records LeRobot datasets from camera and joint topics, runs on-robot inference and exposes ROS services such as `/task/command` and `/set_robot_type`. The ROS 2 graph uses the Zenoh middleware [10]; browsers reach it through rosbridge [11], which maps ROS services and topics to JSON over WebSockets [12]. Earlier versions of our work (v2–v4) extended this stack with a planning engine for demonstration collection, a host training service (`pam_trainer`) that drives `lerobot-train` in the operator's Python environment, an optimisation controller and a custom-robot library with URDF validation. These capabilities were reachable only through the original web interface. PHYSIOS keeps the back ends and replaces the application layer.

III. Requirements

The design was driven by six requirements:

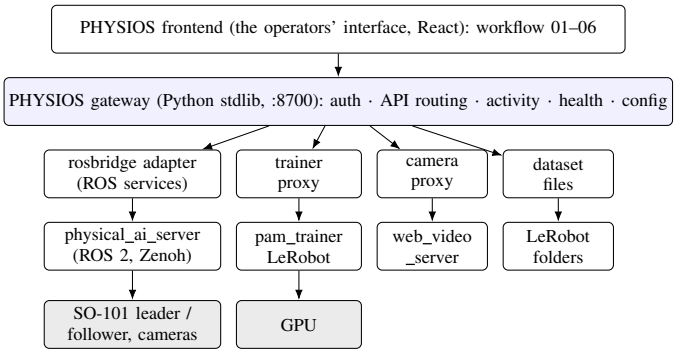


Fig. 1. PHYSIOS layers. Only the two top layers are new; everything below is reused unchanged (R2).

R1 *Independence.* Own frontend, API, navigation, configuration, start-up and shut-down; no dependency on the earlier interface at run time.

R2 *Reuse without modification.* The robot-side node, its ROS interfaces, the dataset format and storage locations stay unchanged.

R3 *Explicit motion.* No start-up path may move the robot; every motion needs a deliberate operator action, enforced server-side.

R4 *Truthful state.* Unavailable services are reported with their cause and a remedy; no placeholder data.

R5 *Operator efficiency.* Dense, consistent screens that show robot, data and training state at a glance, on desktop and small screens.

R6 *Deployability.* Script-based and containerised installation on the robot PC, optional authentication for network access.

IV. Architecture

Fig. 1 shows the layers. The browser talks only to the PHYSIOS gateway, which serves the built frontend and exposes `/api/v1` (REST), `/ros` (a WebSocket pipe to rosbridge) and the same-origin paths the interface uses for training (`/train-api`), camera streams (`/camera-stream`) and dataset files (`/lerobot-data`).

A. Gateway

The gateway is a threaded HTTP server written against the Python standard library only, so it runs in any Python $\geq$3.9 without a virtual environment. Its parts are:

- a **rosbridge client** (RFC 6455 implementation) with reconnection, which exposes typed operations (robot types, cameras, policies, task commands, planning and data commands) and translates failures into structured errors such as `ros_service_missing` with a remedy (e.g. "start the Zenoh router first");
- a **training proxy** that forwards `/api/v1/trainer/*` unchanged, preserving the training service's own same-origin and confirmation-token checks;
- a **camera proxy** for MJPEG streams, so the browser uses one origin;
- **read-only dataset access** with HTTP Range support for episode videos and a streamed `.tar.gz` export;
- **health and host metrics**: six live checks (gateway, trainer, rosbridge, ROS node, camera, datasets), CPU utilisation from `/proc/stat` deltas, and host information from the training service's environment module (imported, not copied);
- an **activity log** persisted as JSON lines; and
- optional **authentication** (Section IV-D).

The gateway is about 1.6 k lines of Python.

B. Frontend

Operators asked that the application keep the interface they already use, page for page. PHYSIOS therefore builds and serves its own copy of that interface (React 19, Redux, Tailwind; about 31 k lines), rather than a re-implementation: an intermediate, separately written TypeScript frontend (version 1.1) differed in many page details and was replaced in version 1.2. Only three changes were made to the copy: all connections go to the gateway's single origin instead of to rosbridge, the camera server and an nginx proxy directly; the connection indicator no longer overlaps a camera view label; and an optional sign-in screen.

C. Deployment

Two equivalent paths exist. Scripts start the gateway (and the training service if it is not running), check every dependency and print service health; they never start motion. A container image holds only the gateway and the built frontend, runs as an unprivileged user with host networking next to the existing robot containers, mounts the repository and dataset cache read-only, and declares a health check. The training service stays on the host because it needs the operator's LeRobot environment and GPU.

D. Authentication

On a loopback-only gateway the operating-system account is the security boundary. Setting an operator token enables sign-in: tokens are compared in constant time; sessions are random 256-bit identifiers in HttpOnly, SameSite=Strict cookies with a configurable lifetime; scripts may use a Bearer token; five failed attempts per address and minute trigger a one-minute block. The gateway refuses to listen on a non-loopback address without a token. Cross-origin POST requests and WebSocket upgrades are rejected regardless.

V. Workflow Modules

Planning uses the existing planning engine to generate per-episode placements of objects and targets within a reachable workspace, validate them and version the approved plan. **Recording** binds each take to a planned episode: the plan's instruction and set-up are shown, the take is started through `/task/command`, and an optional review step accepts or rejects the episode. **Data** lists datasets with review state, plays episode videos, and supports validation, publishing and export.

Training and optimisation. Training commands are built from the installed `lerobot-train --help`, shown verbatim and started only with a server-issued token that matches the reviewed command. Logged metrics feed detectors for non-finite or exploding loss, gradient explosion, stagnation, over-fitting (validation loss rising while training loss falls), excessive clipping, memory pressure and data-loading bottlenecks. For a problem with onset step s, an optimisation session restarts from the latest usable checkpoint before s with weights only (no optimiser state), running a *control* with unchanged settings and up to three trials, each changing levers that the policy actually supports. A trial with final metric m_t is recommended over the control m_c only if

$$g = \frac{m_c - m_t}{|m_c|} \times 100\,\% \;\geq\; g_{\min}, \qquad g_{\min} = 5\,\%, \qquad (1)$$

otherwise the advice is to keep the original settings. Budgets bound the number of trials, GPU time and per-trial duration.

Evaluation records robot trials per checkpoint. With k successes out of n trials, the success rate is reported with the Wilson score interval

$$\frac{\hat{p} + \frac{z^2}{2n} \pm z\sqrt{\frac{\hat{p}(1-\hat{p})}{n} + \frac{z^2}{4n^2}}}{1 + \frac{z^2}{n}}, \quad \hat{p} = \tfrac{k}{n},\ z = 1.96, \qquad (2)$$

which stays informative for the small n typical of physical trials. Training metrics and robot results are kept separate, and a recommendation is labelled robot-based only with at least three evaluated trials.

Inference offers a dry-run model check (live inputs, safety-filtered outputs, nothing published), a host rollout of models trained on the PC, and container inference of policies stored on the robot side. **Robots** registers custom arms from URDF/Xacro archives with a restricted Xacro expander that never executes code, validates the model, renders it, and advances through four readiness stages (registered, ROS verified, hardware verified, data and training ready).

VI. Safety Model

Motion can originate only from four operator actions: starting a recording take (the follower then mirrors the leader arm), *Run* in host rollout, *Start* in container inference, and *Start motion* in the one-joint hardware test (*Run* corresponds to *Start moving* in the interface). The safeguards are layered:

1) *Start-up.* Neither the scripts nor the container start recording, inference or a rollout.
2) *Two-step host rollout. Load model* (after a configuration checklist) starts the worker with the arm still; only *Start moving* publishes commands.
3) *Gateway rule for scripts.* The REST API rejects inference start commands without `confirm: true` (HTTP 428). Container inference started from the interface keeps the original single-click behaviour.
4) *Worker-side limits.* Each command is clipped to a joint envelope derived from the demonstrations (+5 %, tightenable, widenable by at most 10 %), a per-step change limit and a lead limit; stale camera or joint data (> 0.5 s) or a missing operator heartbeat (> 2 s) cause the arm to hold; a maximum duration and an emergency stop end the run; the worker refuses to start if another node publishes on the command topic.
5) *Custom robots.* The hardware test uses a single-use, server-issued plan (at most 0.1 rad at 0.2 rad/s towards mid-range, valid 180 s); a pre-hold detects inverted joints or offsets before the intended motion; the server judges the recorded samples. Changing mappings or limits withdraws the corresponding readiness stages.

A software stop is not an emergency stop; the procedure requires a hardware stop within reach.

TABLE I
Automated validation of PHYSIOS 1.2.0 (11 Nov 2026)

Suite	Result
Gateway (API, adapters, sign-in, same-origin paths)	22 passed
Production build (lint warnings fail)	compiled
Browser walk-through, whole workflow	26/26 steps
Optimisation views	9/9 steps
Sign-in walk-through (script / container)	6/6, 6/6
Training service (unchanged)	91 passed, 1 skipped
Planning engine (unchanged)	45 passed
Container: health check, six service checks	healthy, 6/6

VII. Interface Design

The interface is the one operators already use, so adoption needs no retraining. It has a soft grey canvas, white sheets, black active capsules and a numbered workflow rail. A compact theme raises information density: a 14 px root size tightens all spacing while text keeps its size; cards have a 14 px radius and hairline borders; the rail is 78 px wide; work areas reach 1760 px. Recording and inference use a *console* layout (Fig. 2):

- robot type and connection state top left;
- a camera grid in the centre, switchable to processed, simulated or multi-panel views;
- the planned episode with its instruction and set-up on the right;
- at the bottom, a control bar showing phase, progress and host resources, with the buttons Start, Stop, Retry, Next and Finish.

Services that are unavailable are reported with their cause rather than as empty data (R4).

VIII. Validation

All tests were run in a sandbox without robot or GPU. The robot side was represented by the *real* planning-engine code behind a rosbridge stand-in with a simulated recorder; the trainer was the *real* training service with a stub `lerobot-train` that writes logs and checkpoints and diverges for certain settings; custom-robot tests used a simulated three-joint arm. Table I summarises the results on the final build.

The walk-through runs against the interface served by PHYSIOS and covers:

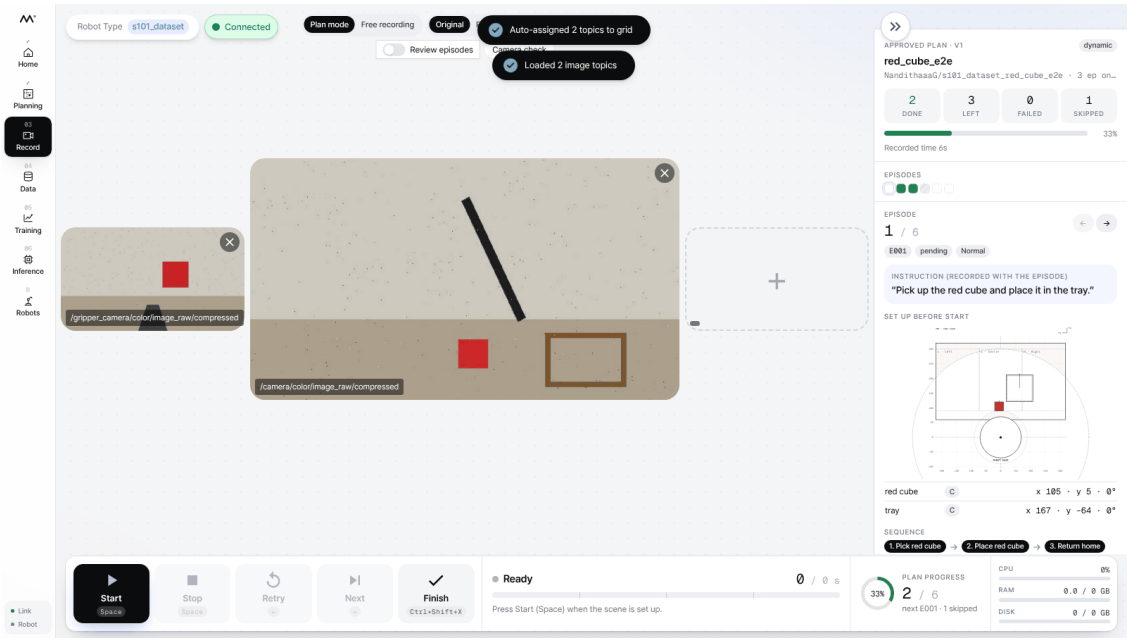


Fig. 2. Record console in PHYSIOS 1.2 (simulated robot side): camera grid, the planned episode with its instruction and set-up, and the control bar.

- robot selection;
- planning with all six strategies, per-episode editing, validation, fixes and approval;
- plan-bound takes with automatic advance, the optional review (reject, retake, approve) and skipping with a reason;
- the processed and simulated views, and free recording;
- dataset overview, episode viewer, review and deletion, publishing and data tools;
- a confirmed training command; and
- the inference panel.

The optimisation check covers diagnosis, recommendations restricted to supported levers, and the comparison dashboard. The custom-robot path ran in the earlier v4 suites on the same interface code (upload, validation and viewer 12/12; readiness and the one-joint test 11/11, with zero commands before Start). The robot pages now reach the training service through the gateway, and the gateway tests cover that proxy. The container was built on a substitute Ubuntu 24.04/Python 3.12 base because public registries were unreachable from the sandbox.

IX. Limitations and Future Work

The central limitation is that no result above was obtained on the physical SO-101 or with GPU training. Outstanding checks are recording and camera streams through PHYSIOS, real SmolVLA training and an optimisation session from a real checkpoint, a supervised low-speed host rollout, and the hardware test on the real arm. Authentication uses a shared operator token without per-user roles, and the gateway does not terminate TLS. Custom-robot server configurations must still be installed by hand. Future work includes measuring how much the planned-collection and review steps reduce the number of demonstrations needed for a reliable grasp, camera-condition matching between training and deployment, and per-user audit trails.

X. Conclusion

PHYSIOS turns a set of capable but separate robot-learning tools into one independent application with a single API, a dense and consistent operator interface, layered motion safety and reproducible deployment, while leaving the robot-side software untouched. The simulated validation is complete for all modules; physical validation on the SO-101 is the next step.

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